ethnic group rebelled against the central regime and also against the Shan–communist alliance,[14] which had retreated into the mountainous regions in the north-east, close to the Chinese border.

There, there were several active military groups, and fighting between the Shan and the Karen was not the only inter-factional dispute. In the period after the end of the Chinese Civil War in 1950, the CIA was actively trying to fund Kuomintang[15] units in northeast Burma to invade China.[16] This situation persisted in the 1950s and fused with the chain of rebellions of the border tribes against Burmese rule and the fighting between the various ethnic groups. The CIA-backed campaign was of particular concern to the Burmese authorities as they feared the Chinese would use the existence of Kuomingtang units as an excuse for invasion. Equally, such a flagrant intervention in their domestic affairs did little to mitigate the military's already strong distrust of foreigners, who were seen as following their own agendas to the detriment of Burma.

In consequence, by the late 1950s the army was embroiled in a complex set of civil wars on Burma's borders and the pressures created by this militarisation of society led to the partial instigation of military rule in 1958, and then to the 1962 coup which saw the official establishment of a military regime.[17] But more than this, the permanent wars that followed independence meant the military lost all distinctions between their internal 'enemies' and civilians[18] who happened to live in one of the rebellious areas.

It also established a pattern of rivalry and tension between those doing the fighting and those ruling in Rangoon, which continued even after the military officially seized power. This led to warlordism, as regional commanders asserted their independence in the regions where they were notionally fighting to re-assert central control. And later, as the wars continued, an officer class formed that was able to grow rich from controlling the economy, especially opium production, while the rank-and-file soldiers were reduced to growing their own food and stealing from the civilians they were meant to protect.[19]

The dispute about the role of Buddhism was also not settled by independence. During the democratic period from 1948 to 1962 Buddhism was mostly seen as a moral basis for public life, but there was less sense that it was an essential part of 'being Burmese'. During the 1970s and